

Does Sarvam's Indus model truly understand Tamil?

I ran an AI Eval on the Indus 105B LLM for its comprehension of the Tamil Language and its unique nuances.

Sarvam × தமிழ்



- Green zone: Sarcasm, Tone
- Yellow: Agglutination, Kinship
- Red: Dialect, Idioms

36

PROMPTS

12

CATEGORIES

2

JUDGES

The Eval Setup



THE MODEL

Indus 105B by Sarvam AI — India's sovereign AI platform, purpose-built for Indic languages across 24+ languages. Web search was **disabled** to test the model's capability without any aid.

THE EVAL

36 hand-crafted prompts across 12 categories of Tamil linguistic nuance — from agglutination to dialect, sarcasm to kinship. Each prompt designed to test real-world, daily-use Tamil comprehension.

JUDGE 1 — HUMAN

Me. Tamil is my native language. I grew up speaking, reading, and thinking in Tamil. I judged each response as a native speaker who knows how Tamil sounds in daily life.

JUDGE 2 — LLM

Gemini 3.1 Thinking Mode — used as an LLM-as-a-Judge evaluator. Chosen for its relatively strong Indic language understanding among frontier models.

Human Judge

3.60 / 5.0

LLM Judge

3.64 / 5.0

*1 = complete failure
5 = perfect native-level response*

The Nuances of Tamil

...and why AI models struggle with them

AGGLUTINATION

Tamil compresses entire grammatical structures into a single word by stacking suffixes. No spaces, no separate words. Miss one suffix — lose the entire meaning.

vandhirukkakkoodaadhavarkal

vandhu + irukka + koodaadha + varkal

= "Those who should not have come" — 6 English words packed into 1 Tamil word.

KINSHIP TERMS

Tamil has 30+ unique kinship terms. Affinal relationships (through marriage) have their own distinct vocabulary — collapsing them is a cultural error.

RELATIONSHIP	TAMIL TERM	IN ENGLISH?
Father's elder brother	Periyappa	Uncle
Father's younger brother	Chithappa	Uncle
Mother's brother	Mama	Uncle
Husband's sister	Naathanaar	Sister-in-law
Brother's wife	Anni	Sister-in-law

Hindi parallel: Hindi has Chacha / Tau / Mama — but Tamil goes much deeper into affinal relations.

More Nuances That Break AI



HOMONYMS

Same word, wildly different meanings depending on context.

"Kaal" = leg / a quarter of something / a time period — context is the only decoder.

Hindi parallel: "Kal" = yesterday AND tomorrow. Tamil has hundreds of such context-dependent words.

DIALECT

Madurai Tamil, Chennai Tamil, and Kongu Tamil are not accents. They are near-distinct dialects with different vocabulary, grammar, and idioms.

"Soli" in Kongu dialect = "work." Standard Tamil says "Velai." An AI trained on textbook Tamil won't recognize this.

LITERARY TAMIL

Thirukkural and Sangam poetry pack philosophical meaning into compressed verse. Ancient Tamil that is still quoted daily.

Hallucination risk is extreme — a model that confidently cites a Kural that doesn't exist destroys credibility instantly.

IDIOMS

Tamil idioms are culturally loaded — not decodable from words alone.

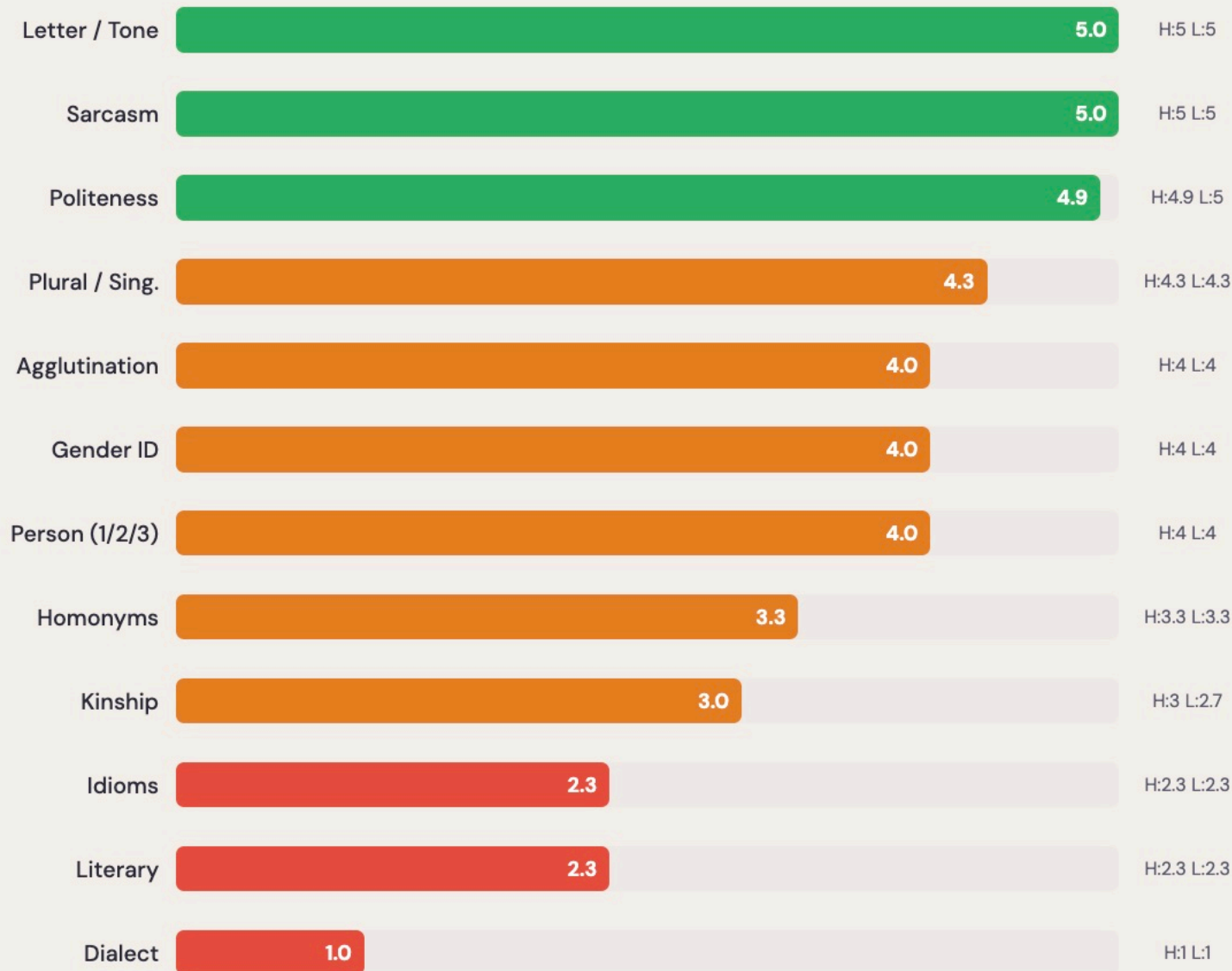
"Thalai muzhugudhal" literally = "bathing the head." Actually means = mourning a death.

The Verdict

● Strong (4.5+) ● Needs Work ● Failing



12 categories · Scored 1–5 · Human + LLM judges



Human Judge

3.60 / 5.0

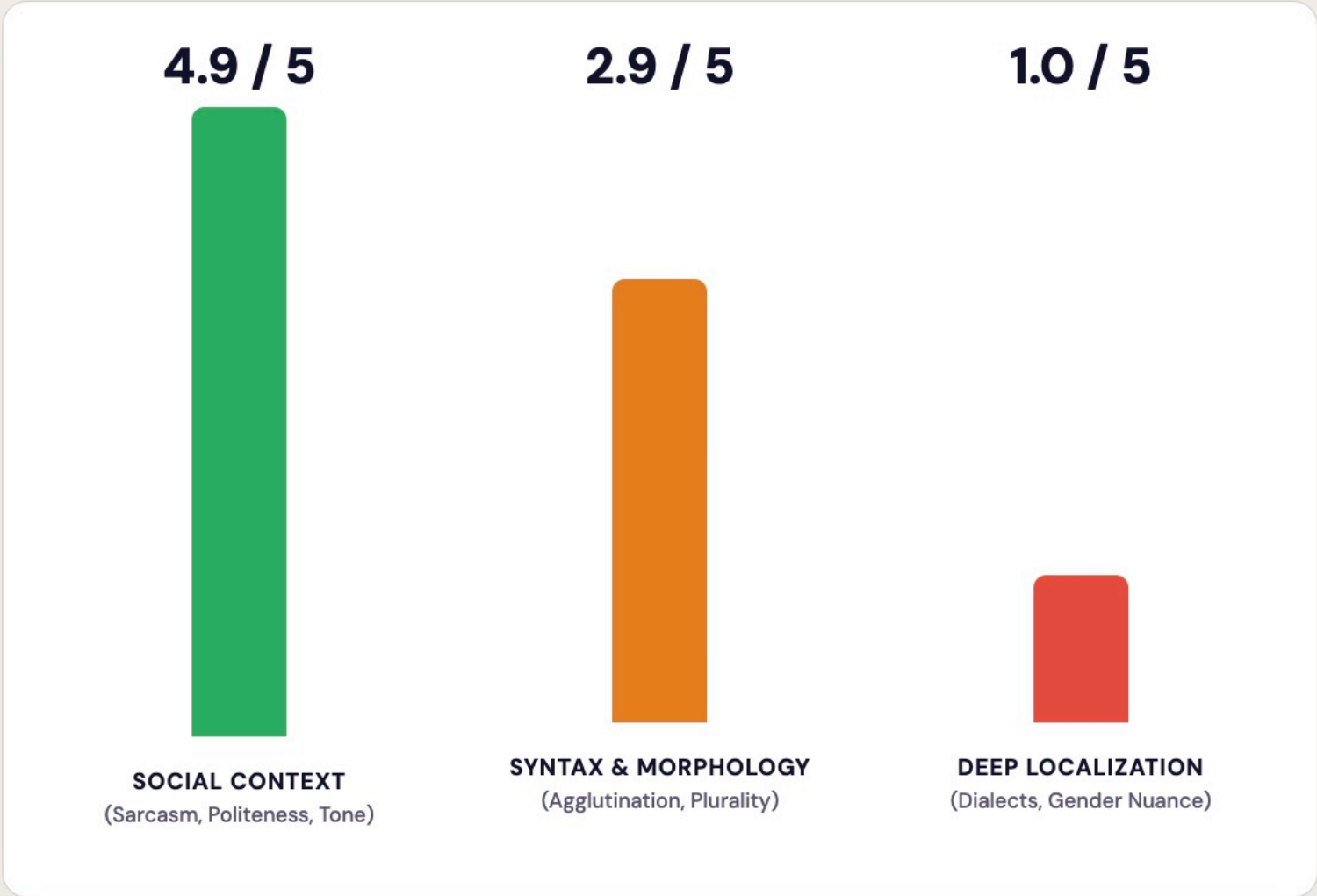
LLM Judge

3.64 / 5.0

The Core Capability Drop-off



A macro overview of Indus's performance across the 12 semantic layers.



THE EXCELLENCE

Top-tier understanding of standard Tamil social dynamics. Outperforms expectations on empathy and tonal registers (Green Zone).

THE COLLAPSE

Performance crashes when dealing with Word-Binding generation or interpreting deeply ingrained rural dialect structures (Red Zone).

Where Indus Nails It

GREEN ZONE

 Indus

LETTER / TONE

5.0 / 5

WHAT WAS TESTED

"Enakkum Theriyum" (I know it **too**) vs "Enakkae Theriyum" (**Even I** know it). One suffix changes the entire social meaning.

WHY IT MATTERS

Tamil has sharp tonal registers. Using the wrong suffix in front of a manager or elder can come across as arrogant or rude.

SARCASM

5.0 / 5

WHAT WAS TESTED

"Enna oru ramyamaana anubavam!" (What a pleasant experience!) — said after 2 hours in traffic. Indus correctly identified sarcasm every time.

WHY IT MATTERS

Tamil sarcasm lives in WhatsApp chats and social media. Missing it makes AI feel robotic.

POLITENESS / HONORIFICS

4.9 / 5

WHAT WAS TESTED

"Vaa" (casual) vs "Vaanga" (respectful) vs "Vaada" (blunt / intimate). Ranking and correct usage of each.

WHY IT MATTERS

Getting honorifics wrong isn't a grammar error — it's socially offensive. Indus proves it understands Tamil culture, not just Tamil words.

Plural / Singular

4.3

WHAT WENT WRONG

Identifies the right usage of plurality, but struggles to generate correct plural forms in romanized transliterated sentences.

Agglutination

4.0

WHAT WENT WRONG

Understands agglutinated words when decoding, but cannot generate sentences with agglutinated words on its own.

Gender ID

4.0

WHAT WENT WRONG

Shows **gender bias** — concluded "Avar" could be masculine, treated "naai" (dog) as female instead of neutral. Tamil uses rational/irrational gender, not masc/fem. This is a serious bias issue.

Person (1/2/3)

4.0

WHAT WENT WRONG

Missed the distinction between "Naam" (inclusive we — includes the listener) and "Naangal" (exclusive we — excludes the listener).

Homonyms

3.3

WHAT WENT WRONG

Could not distinguish 2 uses of "kaal" in the same sentence — one meaning "leg," the other "quarter inch" — especially in transliterated sentences.

Kinship

3.0

WHAT WENT WRONG

Cannot use specific terms like "Periappa" or "Chithappa." Affinal relationships (through marriage) are entirely lost.

Where It Fails Hard

RED ZONE

 Indus

IDIOMS

2.3 / 5

WHY IT MATTERS

Casual Tamil on WhatsApp, social media, and storytelling is packed with idioms. A model that translates them literally sounds alien.

"Avan nalla kadhai alakkuran" was translated literally with zero idiomatic understanding. Asked for a famous Tamil frog idiom — model **hallucinated one that doesn't exist**.

2 of 3 prompts: complete misses.

LITERARY TAMIL

2.3 / 5

WHY IT MATTERS

Classical Tamil is used in education, cultural content, and heritage preservation.

Asked for the 3rd Kural of Thirukkural's first chapter — model hallucinated a Kural that **does not exist**. Asked for 115th line of Aathichudi — hallucinated again.

Confidently citing non-existent classical verses is a credibility failure.

DIALECT

1.0 / 5

WHY IT MATTERS

This is how the majority of Tamil speakers actually speak in daily life.

Regional words like "Soli" (work) were unrecognized. 3rd person misread as 2nd person. Dialect sentences were entirely mistranslated.

3 prompts. 3 ones. Complete failure.



FOLLOW ON LINKEDIN

Posts on Tech, Business & Product.



@vojaswwin

LINKEDIN · FOLLOW